

DROWNED UNDEAD

DROWNED UNDEAD IS A MONSTER SUPPLEMENT FOR 5E THAT PRESENTS MARITIME UNDEAD AS A STRUCTURED DROWNING hierarchy rather than isolated waterlogged corpses. Instead of treating drowned sailors as simple environmental hazards, this book establishes a disciplined chain of command beneath the tide—each rung escalating control, coordination, and the inevitability of submersion.

The intent of this product is environmental dominance and forced-movement lethality without arbitrary CR inflation. Each drowned retains the same core identity—barnacle armor, relentless grappling, and compulsion toward water—while scaling through battlefield control, coordinated assault, and regional authority. No rung abandons the drowning doctrine; each new manifestation deepens it.

Drowned undead are not shamblers, not plague-spreaders, and not mindless zombies. They are coordinated maritime dead driven by singular purpose: drag the living below the waves and make them one of their own.

Their combat strategy is methodical and tidal:

- **Lure.** They whisper the Call of the Deep, compelling the unwary toward shoreline, pier, or deck edge.
- **Seize.** They grapple with unnatural strength, resisting separation and dragging victims toward water.
- **Submerge.** In waist-deep surf or flooded hold, they restrain and suffocate.
- **Coordinate.** Officers amplify forced movement, collapse docks, and churn tides to break formation.
- **Overwhelm.** Commanders convert terrain into water, isolate targets, and turn deaths into reinforcements.

At higher tiers, drowned leaders gain battlefield and regional control—not to increase raw damage, but to ensure no footing remains stable and no ally remains within reach. Legendary and lair actions reinforce environmental inevitability rather than damage spikes.

Cultural lore and motive remain intentionally minimal. Drowned undead may be cursed sailors, storm-lost fleets, harbormasters bound by ancient pacts, or victims of a greater abyssal will. Their origin is yours to decide. Their purpose is not: They drown you.

DROWNED UNDEAD LADDER

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Drowned Sailor	1	Baseline barnacle-armored grappler that drags a single target toward water.
Barnacle Dragman	3	Heavy brute that restrains multiple creatures and advances while hauling prey.
Saltbound Helmsman	5	Undead officer that directs nearby drowned and surges localized tides to break footing.
Tidecaller Revenant	7	Battlefield manipulator that churns water into difficult terrain and compels movement toward the sea.
Blackwater Captain	9	Coordinated assault leader that amplifies forced movement and punishes isolated targets.
Harbormaster of the Damned	11	Regional shoreline tyrant that collapses docks and initiates mass submersion.
Deepbound Admiral	13	Supreme drowned commander that floods battlefields and exerts wide compulsion toward open water.

APEX MARITIME HORRORS

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Stormbound Lighthouse Keeper	15	Legendary undead conduit bound to a cursed beacon, commanding drowned across miles of coast and weaponizing the lighthouse itself.
Abyssal Leviathan	20	Mythic undead sea colossus whose presence warps tides, shatters ships, and births drowned in its wake.

DROWNED SAILOR

Medium undead, chaotic evil

Armor Class 14 (barnacle armor)

Hit Points 45 (6d8+18)

Speed 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	6 (–2)	10 (+0)	8 (–1)

Saving Throws Con +5

Damage Resistances cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks that aren't silvered

Condition Immunities exhaustion, poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages understands Common but can't speak

Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Barnacle Armor. This undead has resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical attacks that aren't silvered.

Drag Beneath. When this undead hits a creature with a Slam attack, the target is grappled (escape DC 12). Until the grapple ends, the target is restrained if both creatures are in water at least waist-deep.

ACTIONS

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target.

Hit: 7 (1d8+2) bludgeoning damage plus 3 (1d6) cold damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Call of the Deep. This undead targets one creature it can see within 30 feet that can hear it. The target must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or have disadvantage on ability checks and saving throws made to resist being grappled or forcibly moved toward water until the end of this undead's next turn.

- This undead opens with Call of the Deep on a target near an edge, then grapples and hauls the target into waist-deep water.
- If it can't reach water, it fights to control space around ledges, gangways, and slick shoreline approaches rather than trading blows.
- Pair it with difficult terrain, low visibility, or tight pier lanes so forced movement decisions matter.



SALTBOUND HELMSMAN

Medium undead, chaotic evil

Armor Class 17 (reinforced barnacle armor)

Hit Points 110 (13d8+52)

Speed 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	18 (+4)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Str +7, Con +7, Wis +4

Skills Perception +4

Damage Resistances cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks that aren't silvered

Condition Immunities exhaustion, poisoned

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages understands Common but can't speak

Challenge 5 (1,800 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +3

Barnacle Armor. This undead has resistance to bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical attacks that aren't silvered.

Command the Taken. Allied drowned within 30 feet of this undead have advantage on checks and saving throws made to grapple a creature or resist being moved.

Tidal Ground. Water within 20 feet of this undead is difficult terrain for creatures of its choice.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. This undead makes two Hooked Gaff attacks.

Hooked Gaff. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 11 (1d10+4) piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) cold damage. If the target is Medium or smaller, it is grappled (escape DC 15).

Surging Tide (Recharge 5–6). Water in a 20-foot-radius sphere centered on a point this undead can see within 60 feet surges violently. Creatures of its choice in the area must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone and pulled up to 15 feet toward deeper water. The area is difficult terrain until the end of this undead's next turn.

BONUS ACTIONS

Call of the Deep. This undead targets one creature it can see within 60 feet that can hear it. The target must succeed on a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or use its reaction, if available, to move up to its speed toward the nearest body of water.

- The helmsman stays near water and uses Surging Tide early to break formation before sending allies to capitalize.
- It prioritizes pulling frontliners away from supports, forcing separation rather than chasing damage.
- Pair with multiple Drowned Sailors so Command the Taken meaningfully increases grapple pressure.



ABYSSAL LEVIATHAN

Gargantuan undead, chaotic evil

Armor Class 21 (abyssal carapace)

Hit Points 472 (32d20+192)

Speed 30 ft., swim 80 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
28 (+9)	14 (+2)	23 (+6)	20 (+5)	22 (+6)	24 (+7)

Saving Throws Str +15, Con +12, Wis +12, Cha +13

Skills Perception +12

Damage Resistances cold, necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities charmed, exhaustion, frightened, paralyzed, poisoned

Senses truesight 120 ft., passive Perception 22

Languages understands all languages; telepathy 1 mile

Challenge 20 (25,000 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +6

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If this undead fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

Tyrant of the Deep. Water within 120 feet of this undead is difficult terrain for creatures of its choice. When a creature fails a saving throw against forced movement in this area, it is pulled an additional 20 feet to deeper water.

Drowned Genesis. When a humanoid dies within 300 feet of this undead while touching water, it rises as a Drowned Sailor at the start of this undead's next turn.

Psychic Pressure. A creature that starts its turn in water within 120 feet of this undead must succeed on a DC 21 Wisdom saving throw or take 14 (4d6) psychic damage and have disadvantage on its next saving throw before the end of its next turn.

Mythic Trait: Dreaming Abyss. When this undead is reduced to 0 hit points, it does not die. Instead, it regains 250 hit points and the sea within 300 feet becomes violently churning. Creatures in water must succeed on a DC 21 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone and pulled 30 feet toward this undead. After this trait activates, this undead gains access to its Abyssal Cataclysm action.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. This undead makes three attacks: one Bite and two Tentacle attacks.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +15 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. *Hit:* 30 (4d10+9) piercing damage plus 18 (4d8) cold damage.

Tentacle. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +15 to hit, reach 30 ft., one target. *Hit:* 22 (3d8+9) bludgeoning damage plus 13 (3d8) necrotic damage. The target is grappled (escape DC 21). Until the grapple ends, the target is restrained.

Abyssal Maelstrom (Recharge 5–6). This undead creates a 60-foot-radius whirlpool centered on itself. Each creature in water must make a DC 21 Strength saving throw, taking 45 (10d8) bludgeoning damage on a failure and being pulled 40 feet toward this undead, or half as much damage on a success.

Abyssal Cataclysm (Mythic Only; Recharge 5–6). The sea erupts outward in a 120-foot radius. Creatures in water take 63 (14d8) bludgeoning damage and are knocked prone. Structures in contact with water take double damage.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

The leviathan can take 3 legendary actions, choosing from the options below. Only one option can be used at a time and only at the end of another creature's turn. The leviathan regains spent legendary actions at the start of its turn.

Crushing Current (1 Action). One creature grappled by the leviathan takes 18 (4d8) bludgeoning damage.

Psychic Surge (1 Action). Each creature in water within 60 feet must succeed on a DC 21 Wisdom saving throw or take 13 (3d8) psychic damage.

Sweep the Deck (2 Actions). The leviathan makes one Tentacle attack.

Drag to the Abyss (Costs 3 Actions). The leviathan violently drags every creature it is grappling up to 30 feet closer to itself and forces them beneath the water. Each creature must succeed on a DC 21 Constitution saving throw or take 22 (4d10) cold damage and begin drowning. While drowning, the creature takes 11 (2d10) cold damage at the start of each of its turns and cannot speak. If the creature fails this saving throw three times before succeeding, it falls unconscious and begins dying. The creature can repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on a success.

LAIR ACTIONS

When fighting in its ocean trench or within a massive body of water claimed by it, the leviathan can take lair actions on initiative count 20 (losing initiative ties). It can't use the same effect two rounds in a row.

Rising Tide. The water level across the battlefield increases by 10 feet.

Crushing Depth. Pressure intensifies. Creatures below the surface must succeed on a DC 21 Constitution saving throw or take 22 (4d10) bludgeoning damage.

Shipbreaker Surge. A massive wave crashes across a 100-foot line 30 feet wide staring at the leviathan. Creatures in the line must make a DC 21 Dexterity saving throw or take 27 (6d8) bludgeoning damage and be knocked prone. Ships and water vehicles in the area take 45 (10d8) bludgeoning damage.

- The leviathan fights in open water, using Abyssal Maelstrom to cluster enemies before isolating priority targets.
- After Dreaming Abyss triggers, escalate the encounter immediately with Abyssal Cataclysm to reinforce mythic scale.
- Use lair actions to alter water depth and threaten ships or structures, forcing constant repositioning.

ABYSSAL LEVIATHAN



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